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“Aane Do Dilli, Seedha Goli Maar Denge” – Middle-Class Hostility Towards Farmers on the Rise, Turning Violent

As the 2024 Farmers' Protests bring agricultural workers to the borders of Delhi demanding a legally guaranteed MSP, a first report on rising civilian hostility — and on why middle-class apathy towards the protest has become as significant a story as the state's use of teargas and internet shutdowns to suppress it.

BY MOULI SHARMA

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“Poor farmers are beaten by police.”

Amid media coverage of the 2024 Farmer's Protests lending little sympathy to agricultural workers from Delhi bordering states marching to the national capital, & plenty to the government using militant & violent means to suppress them, civilian apathy is profound. This is part one of a report on the public perception of the protest, & speculation over why it is what it is.



16th February 2024, New Delhi: The 2024 Farmer's Protests come as an outcry against the central government's ignorance & apathy of the nation's agricultural workers' issues, with their prime concern being the continued refusal to ensure an MSP to Indian Farmers as was guaranteed in both their 2014 & 2019 manifestos. In anticipation of unrest similar to the last iteration of these protests back in 2021 (wherein as well farmers from Delhi bordering States marched to the national capital in response to three then-recent legislations), the government has taken to an aggressive obstruction of Delhi borders.

But with blockades & armed personnel keeping protesting farmers out of their capital, & internet shutdowns targeting protest centres, the steps taken by the BJP-led government have quickly become less about crowd control & more about shutting down the display completely. Measures that were implemented in the hopes of preventing a violent escalation of conflict like last time have immediately turned violent themselves (read: police fire water cannons at farmers, used aerial drones to deploy teargas).

When the talks on Thursday, like the previous two rounds (on 8th & 12th February), remained inconclusive, farmers again abandoned what was a truce they'd temporarily agreed to for the discussion & stormed the Shambhu border, leading to the infamous clash at the Haryana-Punjab border, where police & paramilitary forces fired tear gas shells & rubber bullets at the crowd for the third time. This was not a regrettable result of sudden & increased agitation, but a planned & repetitive intimidation strategy, as social media accounts of the march's organisers were suspended beforehand, as were internet services in Haryana & Punjab. The government also shows no signs of regret as till now no public apology has been made, and no justifications given. Rather, to add insult to injury, an order for another 30,000 tear gas shells was placed by the Delhi

In circumstances like these, where the government itself is doing very little to save face, with the bare minimum of even PR strategies (to be discussed in part two) one would expect public outrage more than or at least close to that during the 2021 protest (which was already not extreme, & this time's response is far more intensive). Instead, what is being observed across the nation, particularly among the residents of the capital, is widespread hostility. What started with a surprising amount of apathy has soon turned into an even more surprising amount of disgust, resentment, & vitriol against farmers. Interviews conducted by the TVE team within bustling markets & residential areas of the city reveal a disturbing reality: the 'lying government' is no longer the common man's enemy, but anyone who opposes it; even if it's another common man like himself.

Parents of children in Board grades were concerned about traffic jams during their children's papers. Borders blockages & disturbed traffic flow for people who commute in & out of the city have become matters of inconvenience,^[1] yet who they hold accountable is not the government who's taking these decisions but the protesters who are 'compelling' it to. There seems to be a collective amnesia over the fact that Delhi is not just the capital of the middle class in & around NCR but everyone, everywhere within the political boundary of this nation. That 'Chalo Dilli' has represented dissent, dignity, & being heard for none other than the *common men* who are silenced elsewhere in the country since before India was even a sovereign state.

'Aane do inhe delhi, seedha goli maar denge. Seedha goli maar deni chahiye inhe,' ('Let them come to the capital, we will shoot them on sight. They should be shot on sight.') Said a shopkeeper in Dwarka. He runs a small business with his family & likes to watch political YouTube videos. He is a man of faith & sells photographs of Gods & Goddesses for a living. He is a kind man.

What changed? What did the farmers do to them? What has made these normal, God-fearing men & women turn against their own kind so suddenly?

When did farmers become the enemy?

Unsubtle Influence: News & Mass Media

Large part of the answer is big & small-scale news reporting, trends, approaches, & subtle quirks of language that are all quantifiably effective tools for public perception control. Viewers & readers need to understand that what the media & information industry performs is not just an act of 'dissemination' but also that of determination. There is a formalized structure to the creation of public perception, leading to the formation of something called the public sphere. Simply put, your opinion has never really been entirely your own.

While it might be ideal for every citizen to know at least the basics, it is ultimately a fact that components & dynamics of the public sphere are not common knowledge. (Read Next Week: Critical Theory for the Layman: Why News Media Hides its Workings from the Common Man) This is no coincidence; the lack of transparency in the workings of mass communication models is in fact by design & the reason why they are so effective in directing public opinion. The next section will explain, without lingo or jargon, what precisely these workings are with regard to the farmers' protest.

'PROTESTERS OR RIOTERS?' THE PROBLEM WITH TV NEWS

Post Friday, farmers stated that they were afraid to clash with the 'brute force' the government is using against them, deploying paramilitary forces as if they are 'the enemy.' They do not wish to clash with the government^[2], Sarwan Singh Pandher, one of the key movement leaders, said. They just want their demands met. The march is a 'peaceful protest.'

The march was again put on hold, awaiting another round of negotiations on Sunday. "When the meetings have started, if we move forward (towards Delhi) then how will meetings happen?" (Movement leader Jagjit Singh Dallewal, Charushree Chundawat, Zee Business). **Update, 20th February 2024:** As of 20th February, another round of negotiations has failed^[3], & the March resumes. Internet shutdowns in Punjab & Haryana have not been lifted, nor have border blockages.

Having established this timeline of events as it has taken place at several of Delhi's borders, we must now look at the trajectory of its presentation & coverage in mainstream media & public perception.

Consider India Today's broadcast^[4] of footage from the Shambhu border, titled "Protesters or Rioters?" referring to visible agitation there, after Haryana Police had fired teargas shells at unarmed civilian protesters.

A pointwise discussion of farmers pelting stones at the policemen standing atop vans & armory, and vandalizing safety barriers as a 'show of strength' was all the segment had to go on about as justification of the agenda, yet there were no questions raised about the policemen themselves 'inciting a riot' when the subject of them pelting stones back at farmers came up. A part of the crowd attempting to dismantle a safety barrier that showed it falling on top of them was discussed only as a humiliating failure of an out-of-control mob, rather than anything warranting sympathy or safety concern.

This is by & large the approach that TV news channels have adopted in discussing matters of police violence toward farmers at the borders. It seems as if the very act of protesting strips you of all dignity & humanity, & thus being treated inhumanely by the government is not only acceptable but understood. Their humiliation & injury are to be celebrated; their victories & competence are to be painted as acts of organised terror.

BILLIONAIRES, CONGRESS GOONS, & KHALISTANIS: BRANDING & PREJUDICE

We'll club unintentionally satirical & cartoonish news channels (See: Capital TV: Chalo Delhi 2.0 LIVE: Farmers Protest 2024 Or A Khalistani Agenda, Know The Truth | Dr. Manish Kumar^[5]) under the subhead of political commentators & miscellaneous opinion leaders in part two. For now, our assessment of public perception is concerned with the influence of formal & traditional news media, which follows at least structural if not ethical tenets of news production, & is taken seriously within the industry. An analysis of YouTube comments under India Today's 'Protesters or Rioters'^[4] broadcast revealed that large-scale support for farmers in the Indian diaspora has been replaced with the same prejudiced ideas that they had so harshly rejected the State for propagating 3 years ago, along with an added desire to see these men violently penalised, from the celebration of the militant attacks to demands for expulsion of these individuals to 'Canada' or 'Pakistan.' The hatred is communally charged & hungry to see the protesters hurt, with some even criticising the Modi regime for going too soft on them.

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SUPPORTIVE COMMENTS, THOUGH RARE, CAN BE FOUND. BUT THE UNFORTUNATE REALITY IS THAT MOST OF THEM COME FROM THE TARGETED COMMUNITY ITSELF, DEFENDING, & NOT DISAGREEING.

There are three primary assumptions that hostile audiences seem to be making about the protesters, with every farmer involved in the Chalo Dilli Andolan being one, some or all of the following, all contributing to a larger narrative that feels more 'anti-Punjabi' than anything else:

1. Khalistanis, i.e. separatist Sikh people who want a sovereign nation for the Punjabi-Sikh community within present Indian territory.
2. Goons in bed with the opposition, the one in power in Punjab being the Indian National Congress.
3. 'Millionaire' farmers, or less radically understood to be landowners as opposed to cultivators, unaffected by farm laws & agricultural policy.

As of yet, there is no linkage of any of the three farmers' groups involved in the process with 'Khalistan' advocates, nor with terrorist groups. Their involvement with Congress is obvious speculation, which albeit natural, still lacks evidential basis. Given the intensive crackdown on the social media accounts & internet activities of those involved in or actively supporting the protest, large-scale or organised views of the country's agricultural masses have been shut down using British Era laws, which does no favours to the idea that the farmers complaints are anyhow disingenuous. On the contrary, nationwide participation in strikes like the Bharat Bandh which are a show of solidarity, suggests the opposite.

2021 VS 2024: SAME PLAYERS, NEW ATTITUDES

It is important to note that, while hints & leads to these ideas may be found in the reportage of most news outlets, due to the striking groundlessness of each, none of the points listed out in the report itself validated any of these claims explicitly. Even government strategy has been a lot cleverer this time around, with spokesmen advertising diplomacy & violence hiding behind censorship & military policy. So what gives?

Consider the following report by India Today during the previous Farmer's protest (See: BJP Points At Khalistani Elements In Farmers Protest, JNU Left-Wing Students Have Also Joined Stir^[61]), a news channel whose reporting stance this time around has lent little sympathy to farmers, could then transparently interpret that 6 distinct individuals shouting separatist slogans at farmer's rallies imply that the movement is disconnected from organisers of the 'Khalistani' agenda rather than part of it, as alleged 'Khalistani elements' seems to be attempting to either infiltrate or defame it from the outside. But even more surprising, is a look at the comments, 9 out of 12 of which were critical of the Khalistani allegations & defended farmers.

"No Khalistani elements. The Govt. failed to understand the demands of poor farmers." "Poor farmers are beaten by police."

In contrast, the majority of the (coherent) comments this time around are:

"These are not farmers, the nation knows their intentions. All these guys are millionaires." "My prayers go out to these Policemen. Please be safe while braving these so-called farmers." "correction - KHALISTAN Protests 2.0" (sic) "Check these farmers' backgrounds. They could be Abduls and Ibrahims in the guise of Taqiya Singhs and Harami Singhs." "These Punjab farmers are a nuisance. While other state farmers are busy working hard. These Punjab farmers are destroying public property."

Communal prejudice & slurs litter these comment sections. Public theories are always more conspiracy than fact, hate speeches seldom contain citations, & at the end of the day, people do have a right to speculate. But hatred, like empathy, does not come from vacuum. Nothing does (read: Hitler's Propaganda Ministry: News is Not What You Think it Is). Even seemingly outlandish ideas are carefully engineered, whether intentionally or unintentionally. The opinions of those labeling all turban-wearing, tractor-driving farmers with communal slurs & vitriol are not entirely their own, just like those labeling them victims of a capitalist regime. You are a product of what you read, see & hear, & while there are aspects of choice to this exercise, the freedom is mostly illusory. Consider the following example:

Below is a brief description of the nightly distribution of supplies by ration trucks during the first week of the Farmers' Protest:

Despite the brutality & lack of support they've been met with (except by opposition parties like Congress who have predictably taken a pro-kisaan anti-BJP stance), the farmers weather on. 2021's 'Chalo Dilli March' was a victory, not only for farmers but for commoners of the entire nation, as the government finally repealed its 3 controversial farm laws after the year-long protest. But this victory did not come easy. A year-long protest on the roads of Delhi outskirts meant nights spent out in the December-January freezing temperatures & afternoons spent out during Loo season. By the end of the year, 248 farmers had lost their lives^[7], including 8 who were killed.

Lessons from the 2021 protests have made the farmers better equipped for what is to come. They are prepared this time around, having brought trucks of food supplies & blankets that are nightly distributed among protest members; a community taking care of its own. The wounded & injured are tended to in these hours, patched up & rested for another day of fighting.

Now consider the fact that the same visuals of food & blanket distribution were broadcast on Indian News Channels with voiceovers of Khalistani & Anti-Punjabi rhetoric. The same clips doing the rounds on mainstream channels as well as more small TV networks broadcast these for entire lengths of programs, somehow managing to frame these men, many of them aged, all of them exhausted, as national security threats for eating food & taking care of each other.

These are not luxuries. Media perception & pseudointellectual attacks on the integrity of the movement seem to imply that a paper plate containing a handful of rice & spilling over dal is the height of decadence that these supposed 'Kulaks,' greedy, rich landlords hailing from Punjab are rewarding themselves with, blankets & tractors being evidence of their hoarded riches. Opinion articles in the present media sphere, written by civilians without necessary journalistic or academic qualifications, reflect this mentality.

Those involved in the ongoing protest own tractors and harvesters—luxury goods that are not available to poor farm workers. They are allied with rich middlemen who are known as arhtiyas in northern India. They are already in a business where they are guaranteed a buyer and a minimum price for their principal products. In other words, the normal risks of business are reduced quite substantially for them. Now, they are looking for guaranteed offtakes and prices for all their products. They also want state-funded crop insurance cover to pretty much eliminate their risks. And they want the state to provide a monthly pension of Rs 10,000 a month to all farmers and agricultural labourers over 60, without farm owners making any contributions, unlike other businesses. One cannot blame the landlord-farmers for agitating. If they can arm-twist the rest of us taxpayers and get their way, why not?

JAITHIRTH 'JERRY RAO FOR THE PRINT, WHY IS INDIA'S LEFT BACKING RICH LANDLORD-FARMERS?'⁽⁸⁾ RAO IS THE FOUNDER OF MPHASIS, & CURRENTLY OWNS THE PRIVATE EQUITY FIRM, HOME FINANCE FIRST, A COMPANY WHOSE MARKET CAP AS OF 2023 IS RS. 6247 CR.

Parts of the population that have lived out not only their lives but entire generations without facing or being part of any political conflict now stand to opionate on & dismiss a national protest as a convenient act of leisurely destruction. Forgetting that hooligans don't stick around to face teargas & rubber bullets, & neither do millionaires. Millionaires, like Jerry Rao, sit in their air-conditioned CEO quarters & read profit reports of the quarter in CRs while writing bullshit opinion^[9] pieces on issues that don't affect them & sending them to all the newspapers that can't afford to turn him down. Millionaires, like Jathirth, have not struggled a day in their life. They've found success & routine built upon generational wealth & caste privileges - which they mistake for their own hard work - & the disruption of this routine inconveniences them.

They see themselves as victims. This is what their dismissal of a capital march or a national strike as immature acts of vain, selfish 'inconvenience' to the common man reveal: they do not know that no one would do what the farmers are doing for frivolous reasons, because they have never had to do it themselves. They have not stood out in the sun a day in their life, let alone worked with their arms & legs. They have not had to scream over the sound of drones & loudspeakers, & eat in huddled crowds cross-legged on the burning ground.

They do not know what it takes.

What makes a protester a rioter? Or a farmers association member, a Kulak? Is it having rice & lentils in a paper plate from a ration-filled truck? Is it weathering the winds of military-grade weaponry & throwing back a stone? Is it wanting to be allowed to march into one's own capital like any citizen of this country has a constitutional right to do? Or is it having a support system, a community, & an organised Union that doesn't allow you to be intimidated & shut down by State forces because you are not alone.

What do the members of an organisation entitled the Samyukt Kisan Morcha have to do to legitimise their woes & identity as cultivation workers? Go back to their field & hang themselves?

By asking & entertaining these nonsensical questions, Indian News media is not raising a query but giving you an answer, telling you what to believe, who to resent, and who to blame. The use of such consistent approaches of reporting from multiple sources within the industry to lead audiences toward certain conclusions & determine topical priorities is known as 'agenda setting'^[10] a media theory developed during the 1968 US Presidential election. And within these, the subtle use of specific language to manipulate viewers & lead them toward certain conclusions should not go unnoticed.

LANGUAGE & TONE: DISTRUST & DESENSITIZATION

Make no mistake, these reports & news bytes are not neutral or objective just by virtue of being written in the third person or being narrated in bullet points. Biases are also & especially dangerous when they are implicit, & a neutrality or an objectivity that overlooks ethical & humanitarian observations has never been a tenet of good journalism in the first place. (Read Next Week: False Neutrality: Cowardice is Not Professionalism)

An unnecessary use of sceptical language works to detract credibility from farmers & imparts to viewers an attitude of distrust toward them, all the while pretending to be written from a formal & 'unbiased' perspective. Farmers did not 'claim' to be bombarded by tear gas shells, they *were* bombarded by tear gas shells. These are documented & verified facts, & this presentation is disingenuous & disgraceful.

Even within the reports of more 'sympathetic' networks, such as NDTV, there is a distinct reluctance to make any sort of active criticism of the government's oppressive tactics. But while this absence of critique presented under the guise of 'neutrality' & 'allowing viewers to form their own opinions,' is a failure of reporting in itself (as already discussed, viewers' opinions *are* being influenced, & media houses are well aware; these reasonings are matters of pretence, an excuse to justify a lack of accountability), what is also noteworthy is the use of detached & impersonal tone adopted specifically while speaking of violence against the farmers. Usage of terms such as 'civilians' & 'citizens' to describe city-dwellers in juxtaposition to 'protesters,' 'agitators' & 'rioters' when it comes to farmers creates a false dichotomy that attempts to dehumanise them in the public eye, thus desensitising the reader to violence conducted against them.

The common man seems to have forgotten that farmers are also common men, civilians, and citizens. They are also people. And it is time for him to remember.

To be Continued in Part Two

1. The Common Man's Indifference: You are Not as Innocent as You Think
2. Pseudo Intellectualism & the Economy: 'Opinions' Ring Hollow in Front of Statistics of Agricultural Workers, YouTube Commentators & Intentional Misdirection
3. Independent Journalism & 'Libtard' Empathy: Why There is Still Hope

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR



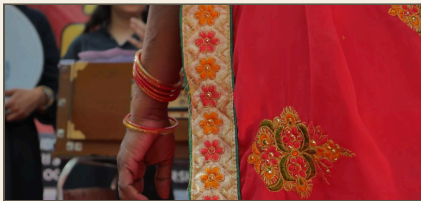
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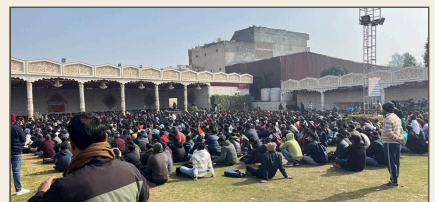
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[1] matters of inconvenience,

[2] They do not wish to clash with the government

[3] negotiations has failed

[4] India Today's broadcast

[5] Chalo Delhi 2.0 LIVE: Farmers Protest 2024 Or A Khalistani Agenda, Know The Truth | Dr. Manish Kumar

[6] BJP Points At Khalistani Elements In Farmers Protest, JNU Left-Wing Students Have Also Joined Stir

[7] 248 farmers had lost their lives

[8] Why is India's Left backing rich landlord-farmers?

[9] bullshit opinion

[10] 'agenda setting'